

Chapter 59 - Kidnapping

After arriving at the hotel, Yan Lin waited downstairs the entire time. She neither called to urge Feng Yue nor presumed to go upstairs to find her - she just sat quietly in the first-floor lobby.

Yan Lin was somewhat of a public figure in Beijing. With people coming and going in the lobby, she was soon recognized. However, they didn't have the nerve to approach her for conversation, only occasionally giving her meaningful glances.

But Yan Lin was already used to being watched. She treated these people as if they didn't exist, just sitting there quietly waiting for Feng Yue to appear.

Yan Lin sat in a position where she could see the entire elevator area of the lobby. She waited with anticipation for Feng Yue to walk out of the elevator and appear before her at any moment.

Yan Lin waited in the lobby for about half an hour before she saw Feng Yue come out of the elevator with a group of girls, chatting and laughing.

The group behind Feng Yue was naturally familiar with Yan Lin - after all, she was the "other people's child"¹ who had always overshadowed them.

The moment Yan Lin saw Feng Yue, she stood up from the sofa, looking like she had something to say.

Seeing this, Zhiyu tactfully led the group of young ladies to the side.

"Miss Feng, we'll wait for you in the car," Zhiyu said to Feng Yue before leaving.

Feng Yue nodded at her, then walked toward Yan Lin.

Feng Yue knew well how attention-grabbing Yan Lin was, so the two specifically went to the adjacent coffee shop to find a secluded booth, where the half-height plants perfectly concealed them.

After the server brought two cups of coffee and left, Feng Yue looked up at Yan Lin and said, "Go ahead."

Yan Lin looked at Feng Yue, somewhat nervous. She leaned forward slightly and picked up the bag she had been keeping at her feet, placing it on the table. Inside was the New Year's gift she was giving to Feng Yue.

The bag was a plain kraft paper bag with no patterns or brand logos on the outside. Feng Yue had no idea what was inside.

However, she didn't want to know either.

"This is a New Year's gift for you, and also to thank you for taking care of me for so long before," Yan Lin said softly, pressing her lips together.

Feng Yue didn't reach out to accept the gift. She didn't even bother to look at the bag. "Yan Lin, we don't need to beat around the bush, and you don't need to give me any gifts. Neither of us owes the other anything."

"We got this second chance at life to correct the mistakes of our previous life. Our dating was a mistake, our marriage was a mistake - perhaps even meeting each other was a mistake. Since some things were wrong from the beginning, all we can do is cut our losses in time."

"We should live lives without each other in them."

Yan Lin stood there stunned and stiff, her fingertips ice-cold. "If... if we really weren't meant to be together, then why did heaven let us be reborn at this point in time? Why not when we first met!"

Yan Lin raised her head, her gaze sharp as it met Feng Yue's eyes directly. Those eyes were full of obsession and determination. "We got this second chance so that we wouldn't repeat the same mistakes. We were meant to be together!"

Feng Yue quietly watched Yan Lin's almost hysterical questioning, her gaze never wavering even slightly.

She was like the crescent moon hanging in the sky - looking gentle and serene, but in reality cold and unreachably distant.

"Yan Lin, there's no 'meant to be' - there's only whether I'm willing or not. I'm someone with a predetermined death date. My condition is indeed stable now, but I don't know if I can survive past that predetermined time of death.

Heaven gave me a second chance so I could live without regrets, not so I could continue this toxic relationship with you.

I don't want to waste what little time I have left on you like I did in my previous life. There are people and things in this world far more important to me than you that need my attention.

We ended long ago - the moment I died."

Feng Yue's predetermined death date hung over them like the sword of Damocles - taboo, unspeakable, and a fear carved into both their bones.

The only thing Yan Lin couldn't face was Feng Yue's death. She opened her mouth wanting to argue, but couldn't say a word.

She suddenly remembered what her mother had said about "correct love."

Yan Lin didn't know how to understand the true meaning of those four words, but she thought that if they continued to entangle themselves until Feng Yue's death arrived, such feelings would definitely be wrong for Feng Yue.

Yan Lin fell silent and lowered her head, her heart aching uncontrollably, even with a stabbing pain.

Seeing that she couldn't say anything, Feng Yue knew the other person had listened to what she said. As for how much she had taken in, that wasn't Feng Yue's concern.

As long as Yan Lin stopped pestering her, that was enough for Feng Yue.

Feng Yue stood up and was about to turn and leave. But then she heard urgent footsteps from the coffee shop entrance, along with the sound of servers trying to stop someone.

Feng Yue looked over curiously and saw Zhiyu with an anxious expression, seemingly searching for someone.

"Zhiyu?" Feng Yue called out.

The other person looked toward the voice, then hurried over with an extremely grave expression. "Miss Feng, Qian He is missing."

Feng Yue's face changed dramatically. "Missing? What do you mean?"

"I don't know the specific situation. Xu Yan is looking for her in the parking garage," Zhiyu said with furrowed brows.

"Let's go to the parking garage first." Feng Yue was about to head out when Yan Lin grabbed her hand.

"I'll come with you." Just as Feng Yue was about to refuse, she heard Yan Lin say to Zhiyu, "You go contact the hotel staff to check the surveillance, focusing on the exits and the area near where the person disappeared."

Yan Lin's voice was steady and her thinking was organized. Zhiyu instinctively did as she said.

Feng Yue had no choice but to rush to the parking garage with Yan Lin.

A guest going missing was serious business, especially when the missing person was someone the hotel absolutely couldn't afford to offend. So when the Sen'er Hotel manager learned of this, he treated it with utmost importance.

The underground parking garage was very large. Although it was Sen'er Hotel's parking garage, the hotel rented out some of the spaces, which meant the garage had constant traffic and was a mixed bag.

Feng Yue and Yan Lin quickly found Xu Yan, who was on the phone while searching for someone. The hotel's security had also deployed most of their force.

"How is it? Any news?" Feng Yue asked with furrowed brows.

Xu Yan shook her head and hung up the phone before saying, "We've already searched Areas A and B, no one there. Now we're waiting for the hotel surveillance."

"Where did the person disappear?" Yan Lin asked.

Xu Yan naturally recognized Yan Lin, though the current situation didn't allow her to be curious about why Yan Lin was here. "It's unclear where she disappeared, but I found Hua'er's phone and bag next to Miss Feng's car."

"Let's go take a look."

The three walked to the car, and Yan Lin began carefully examining the area around the car for any clues.

When she reached the left rear, she noticed something different. "Someone tampered with the wheel here."

Yan Lin narrowed her eyes and almost instantly understood that these people weren't targeting Qian He, but the car owner herself - Feng Yue.

"Call the police first. This is premeditated kidnapping, not an ordinary disappearance."

These people dared to target Feng Yue, which meant they were challenging her bottom line. Yan Lin's aura instantly turned dark, and even Feng Yue standing beside her could feel her emotions were very unstable.

Xu Yan went aside to call the police, and knowing Yan Lin had discovered something, Feng Yue asked, "Did you find something?"

Yan Lin looked at her quietly. "These people weren't targeting your friend - they were targeting you. They must have mistaken your friend for you." After saying this, she looked away and took out her phone to make a call.

Feng Yue couldn't have imagined that Qian He's disappearance was because she had taken the blame for her. But who would want to kidnap her? She usually stayed home making and editing videos - she shouldn't have made any enemies.

Could it be her father's business competitors?

That seemed impossible. Kidnapping was illegal, and her father's competitors weren't stupid enough to go that far.

After Yan Lin finished her call, she turned back to see Feng Yue's tightly furrowed face and comforted her, "Don't think about it. I've had someone investigate the specifics. Once the hotel surveillance is retrieved, we'll know exactly who kidnapped your friend."

"...Thank you."

After reporting to the police, Xu Yan quickly contacted Qian He's father, Qian Yaozhu. Upon hearing his daughter was missing, he immediately began driving back from the neighboring city overnight.

Additionally, Qian Yaozhu told Xu Yan something important - Qian He always wore a tracking device.

With this news, finding her became much easier. Qian Yaozhu even had his family's bodyguards rush to the hotel immediately to help search.

After learning this news, the three of them stopped staying in the parking garage and went upstairs to wait for the people Qian Yaozhu was sending.

They had just gone up when news came from Zhiyu's side - the surveillance had been retrieved and they could see the kidnappers' faces.

Yan Lin looked at the three somewhat blurry faces on the computer screen, her eyes showing undisguised ruthlessness.

These people's target was Feng Yue, not the Qian family's young lady.

Yan Lin sent photos of these three men to Mo Yixu, having him investigate them first. She believed she would soon know who wanted to kidnap Feng Yue.

The Qian family's people arrived quickly, almost simultaneously with the police. As soon as they reached the hotel, they began tracking the device on Qian He, while the police copied the surveillance footage and launched their investigation.

Meanwhile, Qian He, who had been knocked unconscious and kidnapped, was awakened by the sound of loud arguing.

Where was she?

Qian He struggled to open her eyes and recalled what had happened before she lost consciousness.

She had intended to drive Feng Yue's car out, but after getting in, the dashboard warned her that the rear tire was flat. She had planned to get out and check, but as soon as she got out and crouched down to look, she felt a sharp pain in the back of her neck, then passed out.

Looking at the car roof swaying above her and hearing the arguing around her, Qian He roughly understood that she had been kidnapped.

"Damn it, are you three idiots?! Looking at a photo and you still grabbed the wrong person? Idiots! Idiots! Idiots!" This voice was furious, absolutely livid.

"Boss, boss, stop hitting! Stop hitting!" This voice sounded younger.

"Yeah, boss, stop hitting. We grabbed the wrong person - can't we just let her go?"

"Right, right!"

"Right, my ass!" The man called boss couldn't help but give another knock to the three in front of him. "Lao Qi² just called saying the hotel has started searching. Letting her go now would be walking into a trap!"

"Then... how about we just dump her by the roadside? We didn't do anything to her anyway."

"Not bad, I think that works."

"Right, right."

With this suggestion, the others began agreeing with the person who proposed it, and even the man called boss was somewhat tempted.

But Qian He lying in the back was absolutely unwilling. She stopped pretending to be unconscious and sat up in the car with a jolt.

"Hey! You absolutely cannot dump me in this wilderness!"

Footnotes:

¹ "Other people's child" (别人家的孩子) - A Chinese cultural reference to the hypothetical perfect child that parents compare their own children to, typically someone who excels academically and socially.

² Lao Qi (老七) - "Old Seven," a common way to address someone who ranks seventh among siblings or in a group, often used as a nickname.